

Cracking the Titanic Mystery

Name: _____

Date: _____

Year 5 English — Reading

ACARA v9.0: AC9E5LY05

Learning Intention

I am learning to interpret and evaluate an informative text, including how ideas are developed and supported with evidence.

Success Criteria

- I can identify key information and its purpose in the text.
- I can explain cause-and-effect relationships in the text.
- I can evaluate ideas using evidence from the text.

Cracking the Titanic Mystery

On the night of 14 April 1912, the RMS Titanic, the largest passenger ship ever built at the time, struck an iceberg in the North Atlantic Ocean during its very first voyage. Within just under three hours, the "unsinkable" ship had sunk completely, and more than 1,500 of the roughly 2,224 people on board lost their lives.

The Titanic had been designed with 16 watertight compartments, which engineers believed would keep the ship afloat even if several compartments flooded. However, the iceberg tore a series of gashes along the ship's side, flooding too many compartments at once — a fatal flaw that the ship's design had not accounted for.

One major reason so many lives were lost was a severe shortage of lifeboats. The Titanic carried only enough lifeboats for about half of the people on board, since shipping regulations at the time were outdated and had not kept pace with the size of new, larger ships. This tragedy led directly to major changes in maritime safety laws, including a rule that every ship must carry enough lifeboats for everyone aboard.

For decades, the exact location of the Titanic's wreck remained a mystery, sitting somewhere on the ocean floor, roughly 3,800 metres below the surface. It wasn't until 1985 that a team led by oceanographer Robert Ballard finally located the wreck, using a combination of sonar technology and an unmanned underwater vehicle.

The discovery revealed something surprising: the ship had actually broken into two large pieces as it sank, something that had not been confirmed until the wreck was found. Since then, the Titanic wreck site has been studied extensively, though it continues to slowly deteriorate on the ocean floor, and some scientists estimate it may eventually collapse and disappear entirely within the coming decades.

Part A — Comprehension Questions

Q1. On what date did the Titanic sink? _____

Q2. How many watertight compartments did the Titanic have? _____

Q3. True or False: The Titanic carried enough lifeboats for everyone on board. _____

Q4. Who led the team that discovered the Titanic wreck, and in what year?

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Part B — More Comprehension Questions

Q5. What safety law change happened as a direct result of the disaster?

Q6. What surprising discovery was made about the ship's condition on the ocean floor?

Q7. Roughly how deep below the surface does the wreck sit?

Part C — Challenge: Think Deeper

A museum is creating a new exhibit about the Titanic and wants to focus on the theme of 'how tragedy leads to change.'

Q8. Using evidence from the text, explain how the Titanic disaster led to real, lasting change.

Q9. The text describes the Titanic as the 'unsinkable' ship in quotation marks. Explain why the writer chose to use quotation marks around this word.

Q10. Evaluate whether you think the Titanic wreck should be left undisturbed on the ocean floor, or whether more objects should be recovered and studied before it disappears. Justify your view using ideas from the text.

Answer Key — Part A & B

A1: 14 April 1912.

A2: 16 watertight compartments.

A3: False — the Titanic only carried enough lifeboats for about half the people on board.

A4: Robert Ballard, in 1985.

A5: A rule that every ship must carry enough lifeboats for everyone aboard.

A6: That the ship had actually broken into two large pieces as it sank.

A7: Roughly 3,800 metres below the surface.

Answer Key — Part C

C8: The disaster exposed serious flaws in ship safety (not enough lifeboats, outdated regulations), which directly led to new maritime safety laws requiring enough lifeboats for everyone on board — showing how a tragedy directly caused lasting, real-world change.

C9: The quotation marks show the writer is being ironic, since the ship was widely believed and advertised to be unsinkable, but this belief turned out to be tragically wrong — the punctuation signals doubt about the claim.

C10: Accept a reasoned answer either way, as long as it references text evidence (e.g. the wreck's historical importance and ongoing deterioration, versus its role as a memorial/gravesite for those who died) to justify the chosen position — teacher to check reasoning quality.